Who owns memory

Democratic Participation in Digital Public History

Group 3 — Place, Local Memory, Monuments & Heritage

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«Lofos Kapi- Before and after the Holocaust of Kalavryta»

In Greece during World War II, the German occupation lasted from April 1941 to October 1944. During this period, Nazi forces committed atrocities and mass executions of civilian populations, looting and destroying villages and settlements. One region in Greece, in the Prefecture of Achaea, that suffered a devastating blow during the German occupation is the small town of Kalavryta as well as its broader surrounding area.



Map 1. Map of Greece highlighting the location of Kalavryta[1]

[1] Created with the help of Artificial Intelligence

The Holocaust of Kalavryta was part of the Wehrmacht military operation targeted against ELAS forces operating in the area. "Operation Kalavryta" was planned on November 25, 1943, by the commander of the 117th Jäger Division, Karl von Le Suire, and was carried out by the Kampfgruppen (battle groups) led by Woelffinger, Ebersberger, and Gnass. The German forces claimed that the destruction of Kalavryta constituted retaliation for the execution of 86 German prisoners of war by the partisans. The execution of the Germans took place on December 7, 1943, after the order for "Operation Kalavryta" had already been drafted under the directives of Le Suire (Lazaris, 2018: 66-67).

The bloodiest act of "Operation Kalavryta" was the execution of the male population of Kalavryta and neighboring areas, which took place on Kapi[2] Hill (Lofos Kapi). The hill is located approximately 700 meters from Kalavryta, overlooking the town center.



Map 2. Kalavryta and the Site of Sacrifice. [3]

In the present paper, reference will be made to the landscape and to local history, exploring how the hill transformed its status following the execution: evolving from a simple field into a site of execution, a place for holding memorial services (Government

[2] This location was formerly known to locals as Kapis' Field, Kapis' Hill, or Kapis' Hollow (Kapis or Kappis being the owner of the plot).
[3] Archaeological Cadastre

Gazette of the Kingdom of Greece, 1936) for the victims of the Occupation, and nowadays a historical site requiring special state protection, as a location "directly linked to the memory of the local inhabitants as well as the entirety of Greece" as the site of one of the bloodiest mass crimes of Nazism against a civilian population (Government Gazette of the Hellenic Republic, 1993). This research was based on the photographic archive of the Municipal Museum of the Kalavrytians Holocaust. Following the Occupation, this specific location was delineated and gradually began acquiring its contemporary layout.

Chronicle of the site's development:

In 1959, the Cross was constructed at the top of the Execution Site by the Municipality of Kalavryta. The following year (1960), sculptor Anna Vafia created the "Sculpture of the Grief-Stricken Mother" (Figure 7)—a symbolic statue of the Kalavrytian mother, conveying a intense sense of loss that radiates outward through the depiction of the mother embracing her dead child. In the early 1970s, based on designs by Ilias Skroumbelos, Christos Iakovidis, and Giannis Liapis, the monument that continues to adorn the hill to this day was constructed (Figure 8).

It consists of the Cross at the hilltop, while in the lower section, it features slabs of varying dimensions bearing the names and ages of the executed and the survivors, as well as a cenotaph containing the oil lamps (vigil lights) of the families. The arrangement of the slabs is designed to symbolize the siege/encirclement in which the people of Kalavryta found themselves under German forces prior to their execution, as well as the broader encirclement experienced by Greece during the Occupation. At the Execution Site, there are also graves of the executed, created by their relatives in the immediate days following the execution.

Throughout December, as well as annually, commemorative events take place in Kalavryta and the surrounding villages. On December 13, the primary event includes a memorial service held at the Metropolitan Church of Kalavryta. An address follows inside the church (typically delivered by a survivor or a descendant of the executed), and after the conclusion of the ceremony and speech, a procession departs from the church toward the Municipal Museum of the Kalavrytan Holocaust. Passing through its courtyard, the procession continues to the Execution Site, retracing the exact path taken by the residents of Kalavryta on December 13, 1943.

At the Execution Site, wreaths are laid, and the Mayor of the town reads aloud the names of the executed. This event serves as a preservation of memory for the tragedy suffered by the town and the Greek nation as a whole, while on a broader scale, it keeps alive in public memory the atrocities of an era that is distant, yet remains so close.

Moreover, this event remains a constant reminder of memory's profound capacity to color and sustain history, continuously reproducing it and cultivating deep-rooted connections between people and their historical heritage.



Figure 1. Prior to the execution. View of the town of Kalavryta; Kapi Hill is visible in the background.



Figure 2. View of the town after December 13, 1943.

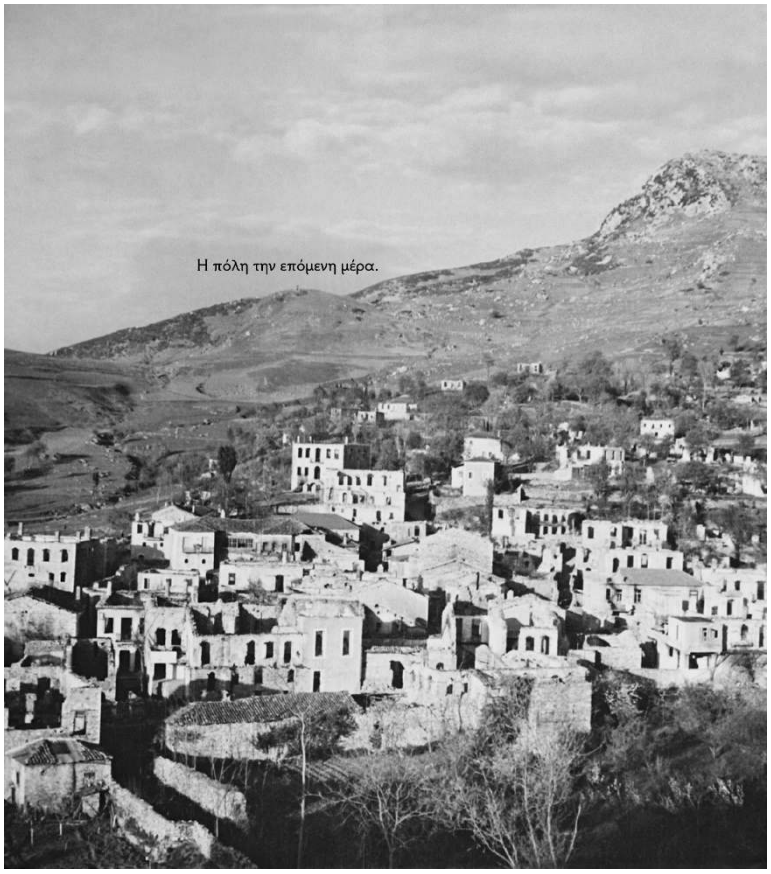


Figure 3. View of the town after December 13, 1943. The execution plateau and Kapi Hill are visible in the upper right.



Figure 4. View of Kapi Hill and its initial layout as a site of memory.

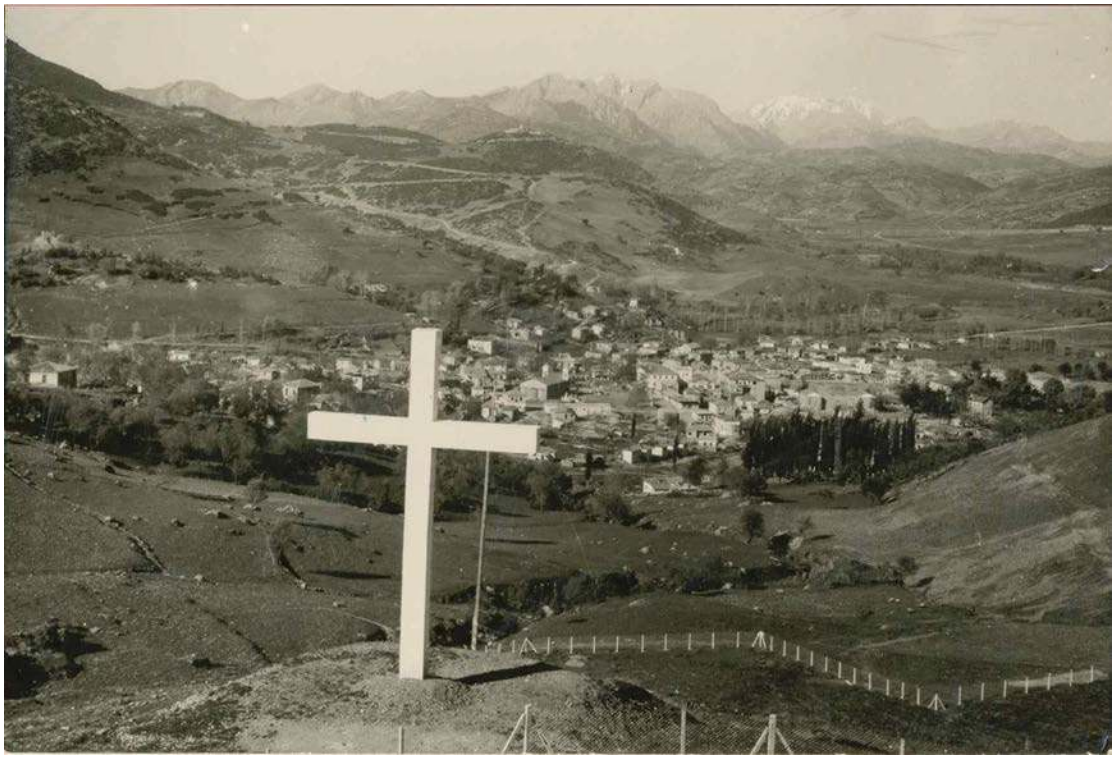


Figure 5. The placement of the cross at the peak of the hill. Kalavryta is visible in the background.



Figure 6. 1960s. The perimeter demarcation and ongoing layout of the site.



Figure 7. The Sculpture of the Turned-to-Stone Mother.[4].

[4] Photographic archive of Eleni Gouvelou

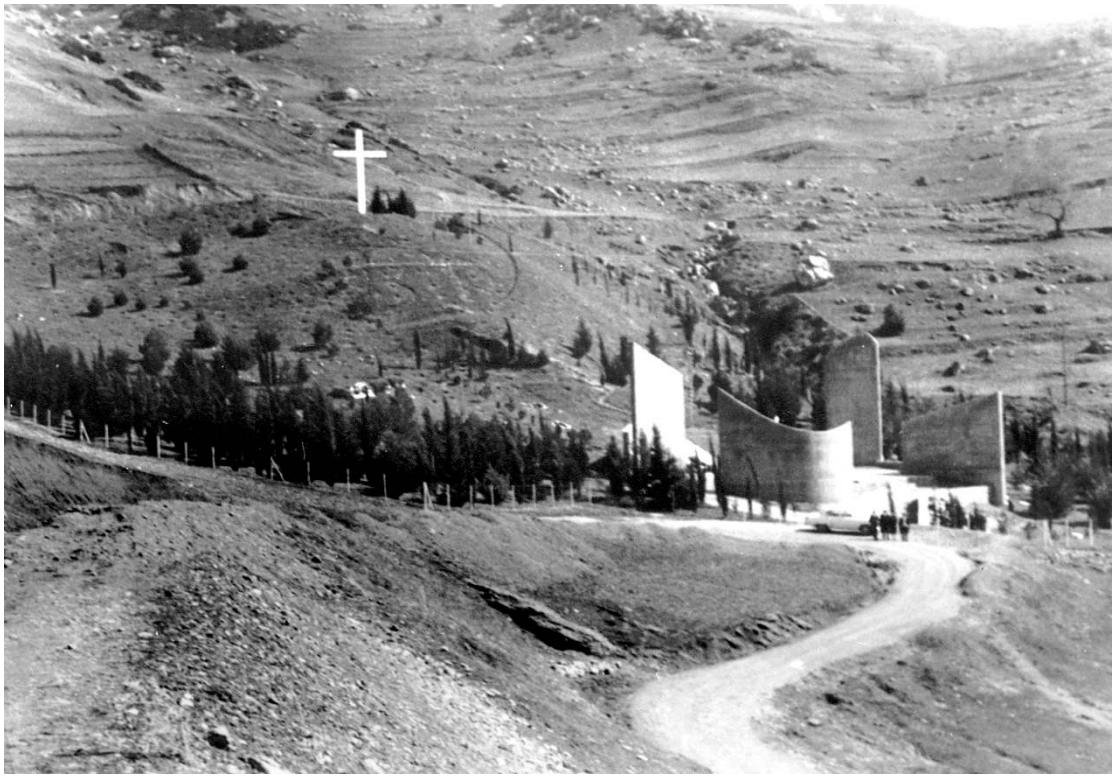


Figure 8. 1970s. The Execution Site following the creation of the monument.



Figure 9. The Execution Site today.

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